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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1966-1974

Coverage Date: 1966-1974

Place Coverage

Kade area, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S): Kinship And Marriage

The system of joking and avoidance relationships determines each individual's actions and attitudes in advance; even the ground rules for joint ownership of possessions and for distribution of food are tacitly understood. The system also serves to provide assurance of mutual aid and to eliminate envy and jealousy. The joking relationship, by permitting free exercise of any selfish acts and the airing of complaints and dissatisfactions, provides a valid and harmless outlet for emotions which might create social tensions and rivalries if allowed to build up to the exploding point.

Marriage usually results from a proposal by a man of the appropriate age to a somewhat younger woman. The couples are often engaged for many years, but a man and woman usually do not marry before the ages of twenty-five and eighteen, respectively. Although marriage generally takes place between people from the same camp or neighboring camps who know each other well, there are times when no woman of the right age is available and the man leaves home to visit more distant camps. Thus it is not unusual for marriages to occur between people living far apart who had previously had no dealings, and for close ties to emerge between widely separated camps, complicating even further the pattern of shifting alliances of camps.

Polygyny is fairly common in San society. Out of forty-four husbands I observed in the Kade area, eight had second wives. This figure corresponds to about 18 percent of the total number of husbands. Divorce is also an extremely simple matter, being accomplished by one spouse's leaving the

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other, so the divorce rate is rather high, although not so high as that of the Hadza of East Africa.<sup>4</sup>

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Marriage

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Polygamy

In San society there is a recognized class of male-female relationships outside of marriage, known as *za-ku*. *Za-ku* resembles what we might call a love affair, but in contrast to the latter it is a socially recognized relationship which continues for some time. The *-ku* of *za-ku* (the reciprocal suffix mentioned in the section on sharing and cooperation) is also found in the word for marriage (*shie-ku*); the male of the pair is referred to as *za-ma*, the woman as *za-shi*. The one case of *za-ku* I observed involved two married couples in a sort of mate-swap, thus creating two *za-ku* couples. This relationship continued for several 107 months, eventually being resolved by the dissolution of the original marriages and remarriages between the *za-ku* partners. Whether the *za-ku* relationship can exist when one or both of the partners is unmarried, I do not know.

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4. According to Woodburn (1968b), divorce is very common among the Hadza; there are approximately 49 divorces for every 1,000 years of marriage. Winter (1956) writes that the divorce rate among the Bwamba is 31.5/1,000 years. For reference, the rate in England from 1950 to 1952 was 2.8, while in the United States from 1949 to 1951 it was 10.4. The rate for the San is estimated to be above 20.

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